

GLOSSARY

Asteroid

A small, irregular Solar System object, made of rock and/or metal, that orbits the Sun.

Asteroid Belt

A doughnut-shaped region of the Solar System, between the orbits of Mars and Jupiter, that contains a large number of orbiting asteroids.

Astronaut

A person who travels to space.

Atmosphere

The layer of gas that surrounds a planet. Also the outermost layer of gas around the Sun or a star.

Atom

The smallest part of a chemical element that can exist on its own.

Big Bang

The explosion that created the Universe billions of years ago; it has been expanding ever since.

Black hole

An object in space with such a strong gravitational pull that nothing, not even light, can escape from it.

Comet

An object made of ice and dust that travels around the Sun in an elliptical orbit. As it gets near the Sun, the ice vaporizes, creating tails of dust and gas.

Constellation

A named area of the sky. The sky is divided into 88 constellations.

Crater

A bowl-shaped depression on the surface of a planet, moon, asteroid, or other body.

Crust

The thin, solid outer layer of a planet or moon.

Dark energy

The energy that scientists believe is responsible for the acceleration in the expansion of the Universe.

Dark matter

Invisible matter that can be detected only by the effect of its gravity.

Dwarf planet

A planet that is big enough to have become spherical but which has not managed to clear all the debris from its orbital path.

Exoplanet

A planet that orbits a star other than the Sun.

Galaxy

A collection of millions or trillions of stars, gas, and dust held together by gravity.

Globular cluster

A ball-shaped cluster of stars that orbits a galaxy.

Gravity

The force that pulls all objects that have mass towards one another. It keeps the planets in orbit around the Sun.

Launch vehicle

A rocket-powered vehicle that is used to send spacecraft or satellites into space.

Light year

The distance travelled by light in one year: 9,460 billion km (5,870 billion miles).

Main sequence

A star that burns hydrogen to helium in its core, a phase that lasts most of its life.

Mantle

A thick layer of hot rock